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Processes to be shut - Windows XP

Application Layer Gateway
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Cryptographic services
Error Reporting Service
Help and Support
Indexing service
Net logon
Netmeeting remote desktop sharing
Remote Registry
System Restore Service
TCP/IP NetBIOS Helper
Uninterruptible Power Supply
Wireless Zero Configuration

Processes to be shut - Windows 7

Application Experience
Windows Update
Cryptographic Services
WLAN Autoconfig
Windows Search
Printer Spooler
IP Helper
Diagnostic Policy Service

them, deleting them, uninstalling programs all leaves data scattered on your hard drive and that's mostly to blame. Defragging doesn't affect the speed of running applications but just the process of moving large amounts of data seems to take a little more time. A defrag on Windows 7 did better than what Windows XP did. Registry cleaning by itself also seems to do little to the system performance and there was almost no difference there.

Moving on to running Windows without a page file enabled, we expected a somewhat large boost in performance. This would be because of the memory handling doing its task instead of sharing it with the hard drive. The physical memory has more bandwidth than a hard drive. There was a substantial increase in performance in startup times with it disabled on both operating systems. Sometimes, not all the changes result in large performance boosts. That was the case with tests run with the page file disabled. There was also a major drop in file transfer times especially while moving large amounts of data. Applications once loaded into the memory performed the same as previous scenarios. Maybe running many more memory intensive applications simultaneously would affect performance. Defragging or running registry cleaners didn't change things around.

The noticeable improvement only came when we also disabled all the unnecessary services from Windows. You can take a look at all boxes to see which services we disabled in either operating system. Keep in mind that specific applications might require some of these processes, so be aware of the ones you've turned off in case you turn them on again. The boot-up times and application times improved even further and the drop in file copy tests improved somewhat but not as much as on a clean install.

To turn off services, click on Start > Run. Type services.msc and right click on the process, click on Stop. Next, disable the process by right-clicking on the process and clicking on Properties.

So what's recommended..?

By looking at all the scores across all tests, turning off processes is the way to go. We've seen that turning on a single process or turning it off takes a couple of seconds. It helps in boot up and shutdown times and also saves a ton of memory. Turning off the page file completely is a bad idea in general no matter how much memory you have. Letting Windows set a page file is fine but if you want to limit the amount, setting a 2 GB or 4 GB file on one of your partitions is fine. When an application crashes, the physical memory will run out quickly and eventually slow down everything.

For those who've wondered whether Windows 7 is any better than Vista or XP, then the answer is yes, it is. We saw this in a lot of the tests we ran. File transfer speeds showed the biggest difference and even after being heavily loaded with data and software, there wasn't the same drastic drop in file copy speeds that could be seen on Windows XP. Quake III Arena running on the same graphics driver versions showed a tiny but yet, appreciable 3 per cent jump in frame rates. Applications which normally feel lighter and launch quicker, in fact are loading faster on Windows 7. We noticed a tiny drop in Firefox performance on Windows 7 and in general, start-up times lag behind Windows XP. With faster systems than the one we used, it's even better. It's also the fact that Windows 7 seems to degrade a little slower than Windows XP when you install all kinds of rubbish on it. So all in all, it's thumbs up for Windows 7 from us. **d**



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